



Combat Mindset — Proposed Way Forward

Joint NZALC and Human Performance Cell response to COMDT ACS

HARDER TO KILL

Proposed Warfighter Focus line — subject to sponsor endorsement

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Purpose

This paper responds to COMDT ACS direction of 16 July 2026 for NZALC and the Human Performance Cell to jointly develop a strategy to close the Combat Mindset doctrine and policy gap. It proposes an agreed problem statement, a terminology construct for decision, a programme of work, interim governance arrangements, and an approach for mapping and appropriately nesting existing training products beneath an Army Combat Mindset Framework.

1. The problem

Army does not currently have an endorsed, Army-wide definition, doctrine, governance or assurance model for Combat Mindset, despite the term being in active use and despite Army's drive toward an increased Warfighter Focus. The COMDT ACS guidance and the NZALC capability note reach the same diagnosis:

Substantial relevant capability already exists across ACS, NZALC, the Human Performance Cell, NZDF Psychology, ILD, training establishments and force employers. The challenge is not primarily a lack of content. It is a lack of visibility, integration, common terminology, strategic ownership and assurance across that existing capability.

The underlying operational problem remains as stated in the NZALC capability note:

Under operational pressure, trained individuals and teams do not always retain access to their full capability.

Sufficient evidence and existing capability are available to commence governance, mapping and framework development immediately. The present gap is principally institutional and integrative.

2. Terminology — decision sought

The COMDT ACS guidance and the NZALC capability note differ on one structural point: which term sits at the top of the hierarchy. This is the single decision required before the framework can be drafted. Two options are offered.

Option 1 — Combat Mindset as the operational frame; Performance Under Pressure as the underlying capability (recommended)

Combat Mindset is the Army-owned operational frame and orienting purpose, aligned to Warfighter Focus. Performance Under Pressure is the trained individual and collective capability beneath it: the capacity to prepare for, remain effective through, adapt within and recover from pressure. Harder to Kill is proposed as a supporting Warfighter Focus communication line, subject to sponsor endorsement, rather than as part of the formal definition.

Combat Mindset explains why the capability matters to Army. Performance Under Pressure explains what must be developed and sustained in individuals, teams, leaders and systems.

- Preserves Combat Mindset as the recognisable, operationally credible Army frame.
- Keeps the underlying capability applicable Army-wide — command, crisis response, garrison leadership and high-risk technical activity, where pressure exists without an enemy.
- Guards against Combat Mindset being misread as aggression or motivation alone.
- Allows doctrine, the framework, training products and delivery organisations to nest cleanly beneath the frame.

Option 2 — Combat Mindset as the umbrella capability

Combat Mindset is the overarching capability, integrating leadership, human performance, resilience, mental skills and performance cognition, with performance under pressure expressed as its intended effect.

- Maximises simplicity: one term, one capability, one framework.
- Risks excluding the majority of Army activity that is demanding but not combat, and re-importing the definitional confusion identified in the capability note.

Both options deliver the end state described in the COMDT ACS guidance. NZALC and HPC jointly recommend Option 1, and will implement whichever option COMDT ACS selects.

3. What already exists

A full capability and product map will be completed during Phase 1. Initial holdings include the following.

NZALC Performance Under Pressure package

NZALC delivers a leadership-development approach incorporating Performance = Potential – Interference, Red Head–Blue Head, Prepare–Perform–Recover, mental-skills techniques, psychometrics, experiential activity, feedback and Leadership Development Plans. This material is embedded across Lead Self, Lead Teams, Lead Leaders and Lead Systems.

Human Performance Cell Cognitive Conditioning programme (COGCON)

COGCON is a developmental cognitive-conditioning product designed to train selected dimensions of performance cognition under physical and cognitive load: arousal regulation, attention, cognitive control, working memory, performance monitoring and self-knowledge. Its most mature and potentially scalable component is an adaptive dual-task training module combining a tablet-based cognitive task with a concurrent job-relevant information task, progressive difficulty and performance feedback.

COGCON has demonstrated feasibility, participant acceptability and promising training trends in limited military cohorts. It has not yet been validated as a measure of operational

readiness or proven through controlled research to improve real-world military performance. Its current status is therefore that of an emerging, evidence-informed training product rather than an endorsed Army-wide capability system.

NZDF Psychology, ILD and other stakeholders

These organisations hold additional professional expertise, learning products, delivery capability and assurance functions that will be confirmed during Phase 1 mapping.

Initial review indicates considerable conceptual alignment across existing products. The Army Combat Mindset Framework will establish a common doctrinal language beneath which individual products and methods can be appropriately nested. It will not require all products to use identical internal methodologies, provided they align to the endorsed framework, outcomes and assurance requirements.

4. COGCON minimum viable product

For the purposes of the Combat Mindset programme of work, COGCON will initially be treated as a minimum viable product within the performance-cognition strand of the broader framework.

The COGCON MVP comprises:

- a short adaptive dual-task activity embedded within existing physical or military training;
- a tablet-delivered attention and inhibition task;
- a concurrent prerecorded operational information task, such as an audio brief;
- immediate recall questions or objective job-task scoring;
- controlled difficulty levels and defined progression criteria;
- selected arousal-regulation techniques;
- basic performance feedback and longitudinal training records; and
- a train-the-trainer and assurance package allowing delivery by existing training staff.

The MVP does not constitute:

- a standalone Army course;
- a complete Combat Mindset or Performance Under Pressure programme;
- a selection, promotion or diagnostic tool;
- a validated measure of operational readiness; or
- a commitment for HPC personnel to deliver the product across Army.

HPC will retain technical stewardship of the COGCON method and provide specialist advice, product development, train-the-trainer support and proportionate assurance within available capacity. Routine delivery, if subsequently approved, will be undertaken through existing training establishments, instructors and physical-training staff.

5. Proposed programme of work

Phase 0 — Governance and definition (by end July 2026)

Confirm interim sponsorship and capability-integration arrangements, endorse the problem statement, select the terminology option at paragraph 2, and draft the Army-endorsed definitions of Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure for staffing.

Phase 1 — Capability and product mapping (August 2026)

Map existing doctrine, content, products, courses, instructor capability, delivery activity, evidence, ownership and assurance arrangements across ACS, NZALC, HPC, NZDF Psychology, ILD, training establishments and selected force employers. The mapping will distinguish:

- doctrinal and policy holdings;
- capability outcomes;
- training products and methods;
- delivery organisations;
- technical and professional authorities;
- evidence maturity;
- scalability and resource requirements; and
- gaps, duplication and integration opportunities.

COGCON will be assessed as one developmental product within this map, with particular attention to its MVP boundary, evidence base, ownership, workforce requirements and scalability.

Phase 2 — Framework and product architecture (September 2026)

Draft the Army Combat Mindset Framework, including the endorsed definition and desired operational effect; the integrated capability strands; developmental outcomes from Lead Self through Lead Systems; the relationship between doctrine, framework, products and delivery; common assurance principles; and the criteria by which existing and future products may be recognised as contributing to the framework.

Existing products, including the NZALC Performance Under Pressure package and the COGCON MVP, will be mapped beneath the relevant capability strands rather than treated as the framework itself.

Phase 3 — Stakeholder forum (September 2026)

Convene ACS, NZALC, HPC, NZDF Psychology, ILD, selected training providers and force employers to refine the framework, product architecture, governance model and implementation priorities.

Phase 4 — Limited MVP integration trial (October 2026, subject to capacity)

Conduct a controlled trial of the draft framework and the COGCON MVP within one existing ACS or NZALC training activity. The trial will:

- use existing delivery staff and training infrastructure;

- incorporate one bounded COGCON adaptive dual-task activity;
- test whether the product nests coherently beneath the draft framework;
- assess instructor burden, delivery consistency and participant usability;
- collect proportionate training and implementation evidence;
- avoid readiness certification or high-stakes personnel assessment; and
- identify the workforce, technology, assurance and funding requirements for any wider implementation.

HPC will provide the protocol, specialist advice and limited evaluation support. NZALC or the relevant training provider will lead delivery and structured review. The trial will not create an enduring obligation for HPC to provide routine delivery.

Phase 5 — Report back (November 2026)

Present Framework v1.0, the validated capability and product map, the results of any limited MVP integration trial, the proposed governance and assurance model, and a prioritised implementation plan. The report will identify whether COGCON should remain a developmental product; undergo further controlled evaluation; be integrated selectively into existing training; be prepared for broader scaling; or cease or change direction.

6. Governance

The following arrangements are proposed for confirmation at Phase 0. Technical and professional authority is distributed by domain; no single organisation owns the evidence base for the entire capability.

- Army Sponsor — strategic owner of the Combat Mindset capability at Army level.
- Interim capability integrator — COMDT ACS, coordinating framework development, stakeholder engagement and recommendations to the Army Sponsor.
- Capability development and delivery coordinator — ACS, leveraging NZALC and wider ACS expertise, intellectual property and programmes.
- COGCON product steward and performance-cognition adviser — Human Performance Cell, responsible for the integrity and further development of the COGCON method and for specialist advice on cognitive conditioning and proportionate measurement, within available capacity.
- Domain advisers and authorities — NZDF Psychology, ILD, physical-performance specialists, doctrine staff and other relevant organisations, providing technical or professional advice within their respective domains.
- Delivery agencies — training establishments, units and existing instructor workforces approved to deliver recognised products.
- Assurance — a layered assurance model covering doctrine, evidence, professional content, learning design, delivery quality and operational relevance, with sufficient independence from individual product owners and delivery organisations.

7. Recommendations

It is recommended that COMDT ACS:

1. **Endorse the problem statement** at paragraph 1.
2. **Endorse Combat Mindset as the Army operational frame** and Performance Under Pressure as the underlying individual and collective capability.
3. **Note that existing programmes and products will be mapped beneath the framework** and will not constitute the framework in isolation.
4. **Endorse COGCON's interim status as a developmental MVP** within the performance-cognition strand.
5. **Confirm COMDT ACS as the interim capability integrator** pending confirmation of the Army Sponsor.
6. **Confirm HPC as the COGCON product steward and performance-cognition adviser**, rather than the technical authority for the full Combat Mindset capability.
7. **Approve the revised programme of work**, including capability and product mapping, framework development, stakeholder engagement and a limited MVP integration trial subject to resource availability.
8. **Direct that the November 2026 report provide** Framework v1.0; the validated capability and product map; a governance and assurance model; an assessment of COGCON's evidence, scalability, resource requirements and appropriate future role; and a prioritised implementation plan.

Annex A — Initial capability and product architecture

A1. Framework levels

Framework level	Composition
Army operational frame	Combat Mindset
Underlying capability	Performance Under Pressure
Capability strands	Leadership; mental skills; performance cognition; resilience and recovery; physical performance; professional identity and values; individual and collective exposure to pressure
Training products and methods	NZALC Performance Under Pressure package; COGCON MVP; NZDF Psychology products; scenario and experiential training; physical conditioning; structured reflection and recovery; other products identified during Phase 1 mapping

A2. COGCON current nesting

Attribute	COGCON current position
Capability strand	Performance cognition
Primary level	Individual / Lead Self
Secondary applicability	Selected Lead Teams activity
Product status	Developmental MVP
Current contribution	Arousal regulation, attention, cognitive control, working memory, performance monitoring and adaptive dual-task conditioning
Current evidence	Feasibility, acceptability and promising training trends
Not yet established	Causal effectiveness, far transfer, operational-readiness validity and Army-wide scalability
Product steward	Human Performance Cell
Likely delivery model	Existing instructors or physical-training staff following standardisation and train-the-trainer preparation
Assurance	HPC for COGCON product integrity; broader framework assurance through the agreed governance system

A3. Division of functions

Function	Lead	Output
Define and govern	Army Sponsor / ACS	Endorsed doctrine, definitions, policy direction and capability outcomes

Function	Lead	Output
Integrate capability	ACS	Framework, product architecture, stakeholder coordination and implementation priorities
Develop products	Relevant product owner	Product design, protocols, instructor materials and updates
Provide domain advice	Relevant technical or professional adviser	Specialist advice within leadership, psychology, cognition, learning design, physical performance and other domains
Deliver	Approved training establishments, units and existing instructor workforces	Routine delivery of recognised products
Measure training performance	Delivery organisation, using approved methods	Proportionate training feedback and product-level performance data
Evaluate product effectiveness	Product owner, with independent evaluation or research support	Evidence of feasibility, effectiveness, transfer and scalability
Assure	Layered governance and domain authorities	Doctrine, evidence, professional, learning, delivery and operational assurance
Review and recover	Relevant leadership and training systems	Reflection, feedback, recovery and developmental planning

A4. Shared frames

- Prepare–Perform–Recover provides a common delivery rhythm across recognised products and methods.
- Lead Self to Lead Systems provides the developmental progression: individual conditioning is likely to be densest in initial and individual training, while leadership, team and systems application deepens across the leadership continuum.
- COGCON currently contributes principally to selected Prepare and Perform activities within the performance-cognition strand. NZALC and other leadership-development products provide broader preparation, application, structured review and recovery.